



UP AND DOWN

▶ **ASKHAY KUMAR** for four hits in a row

THE TAJ MAHAL for being voted one of the Seven Wonders

RAJNIKANT for making *Sivaji* the Boss of more than just the South

KAREENA KAPOOR for playing the funjabi girl in *Jab We Met*

HIMESH RESHAMMIYA for making audiences see beyond his nose

▶ **RAM GOPAL VARMA** for remaking *Sholay*

JAISALMER for not heeding warnings about the fort's collapse

RANI MUKERJI for repeating herself

CHIRANJEEVI for not giving his daughter Srija the freedom to love

SONU NIGAM for his sordid allegations

THE COLOUR BLUE for driving audiences colour blind in *Saawariya*

Rum Pum or the star-spoiled remake of *Sholay*.

Offscreen, the catfights got cattier, and they were not always between the cats. Jackets were exchanged as were pleasantries, but the big fight of the year refused to be knocked out. The angry young man and the man who increasingly looked like his successor in the hearts and minds of Indian audiences (or at least those who spoke Hindi) sparred over a television show. Fittingly, it was the big daddy of game shows, *Kaun Banega Crorepati*, for reality TV was the star among general entertainment channels (of which there were at least three more by the year-end). Reality shows became the vehicles of star launches, Bollywood launches, even channel launches, and almost outshone the soaps in their melodrama count, with more than their share of name-calling, finger-wagging and head-bashing. The genre also gave India its biggest export, Shilpa Shetty, who went overnight from an item girl to the ultimate It Girl by playing princess of poise to Britain's white trash on *Celebrity Big Brother*.

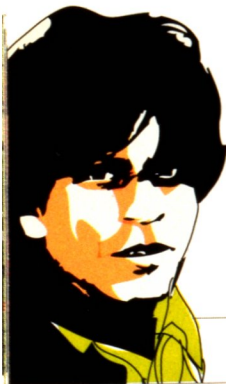
The biggest clash of the year was between two big ideas. One was the monopoly of thought, practised by an odd array of individuals, from Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi to Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, and the other was the democracy of intellect and action. For every M.F. Husain who painted his creativity on canvas, there was a court in Haridwar that issued summons for obscenity; for every television network that went after corrupt politicians and inefficient public servants, there was a minister waiting to pontificate on the podium of privacy; for every Richard Gere who tried to kiss Shetty, there was a magistrate who thought they had denigrated Indian culture.

As Indians played fast and loose with their physicality—there was more naked flesh on display in print and onscreen than ever before—they seemed to retreat in their acumen. As the world became flat, their minds seemed to have become concave. So though there were live telecasts of candlelit vigils protesting Rizwanur Rehman's death, there was no reaction forthcoming from Priyanka Todi to suggest we were living in the 21st

century, where people were free to love and live as they wanted. And though there was much verbal breast-beating about Taslima Nasreen's hounding out, there was no promise of protection for her. In the much-vaunted Planet India, the mind was not without fear and the head was not held high. So there were over 60 news channels and little information, increasing avenues of expression but limited artistic creativity, and more movies than ever but fewer movie stars.

This was a celebrity culture that dulled the senses and skewed the worldview. Why is Rakhi Sawant upset? Just after the break, but for now, more on who killed Benazir Bhutto. What does Aamir Khan have to say about his brother Faisal? Straight up after more on Narendra Modi's chances in Gujarat. It wasn't just a question of low-brow blending with high-brow. After all, Steven Johnson has already told us that everything bad is good for us. It was a question of knowing what matters from what didn't. The world of entertainment, with its non-stop carousel of the weird and the wonderful, seemed to dominate over the less weird and the less wonderful, but much more worthwhile. Which may be why even self-respecting, high-minded individuals started behaving like they were of species Rakhi Sawantus. Manmohan Singh broke his reserve and alleged the Opposition leaders had held hawans to prevent his ascent. L.K. Advani declared the prime minister was no politician. Pramod Mahajan's family behaved like soap opera stars out of their Kanjeevarams. Sonia Gandhi quoted lines written by a Bollywood lyricist and Narendra Modi employed an army of advertising men and stylists to woo voters with his version of the six-pack, the 56-inch chest.

The celebrity body became a changeable thing. Shah Rukh Khan's six-pack became a smart sales pitch for his *Om Shanti Om*, John Abraham's bare chest became the subject of an ad campaign, and M.S. Dhoni's muscles sold biscuits. And Sawant? Well, she just blew the lid off every nip and tuck, every lift and injection that every Bollywood starlet—as well as some stars—have

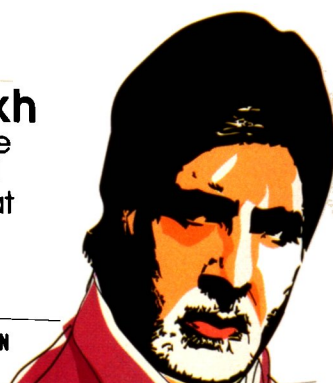


SHAH RUKH KHAN ON
KAUN BANEGA CROREPATI

Amitabh Bachchan is like the sky for us. That's why the colour of the sets was blue. But *main is desh ka lal hoon* (I am the country's darling), so it is red.

I am old and Shah Rukh

is young and I agree that he is smart and sexy. Let us see what happens to him after 35 years.



AMITABH BACHCHAN ON
SHAH RUKH KHAN